DIETARY XENOANTIGENS AS MODULATING VARIABLES IN FACIOSCAPULOHUMERAL MUSCULAR DYSTROPHY:

A Hypothesis Linking Neu5Gc Xenosialitis and ATI-Driven Systemic Inflammation to DUX4 Reactivation, Sarcolemmal Oxidative Stress, and Satellite Cell Suppression in FSHD

Martin Hamer, RN (Ret.)

Independent Researcher | Hamer Glycan Systems | hamerglycans.com | 2026

Abstract

Background: Facioscapulohumeral muscular dystrophy (FSHD) is the third most common inherited muscular dystrophy, affecting approximately 1 in 8,000 individuals globally. It is caused by the aberrant reactivation of the DUX4 transcription factor in skeletal muscle, producing a programme of myocyte toxicity, inflammation, and progressive muscle atrophy. A defining and clinically significant feature of FSHD is its marked variability in both penetrance and rate of progression — even among individuals carrying identical genetic lesions. This variability is incompletely explained by genetic and epigenetic factors alone, and the search for modifiable environmental variables that influence DUX4 expression and disease severity represents one of the most important open questions in FSHD research.

Hypothesis: We propose that chronic dietary exposure to two specific xenoantigens — N-glycolylneuraminic acid (Neu5Gc) from bovine red meat and dairy products, and wheat-derived amylase-trypsin inhibitors (ATIs) and gliadins — constitutes a previously unrecognised, modifiable environmental variable that accelerates FSHD progression through two convergent mechanisms. Mechanism One: Neu5Gc xenosialitis at the sarcolemma generates chronic oxidative stress at the muscle cell membrane, creating the oxidative microenvironment that promotes DUX4 reactivation from its epigenetically silenced state. Mechanism Two: ATI-driven systemic TNF-α elevation suppresses myogenic satellite cell proliferation and differentiation, impairing the muscle's endogenous repair capacity and accelerating the net loss of functional muscle fibre that characterises disease progression.

Significance: FSHD currently has no approved disease-modifying therapy. Management is supportive, focused on physiotherapy, pain management, and adaptive equipment. If dietary xenoantigens constitute a modifiable upstream variable in DUX4 expression and muscle repair impairment, their elimination represents a zero-cost, zero-risk intervention with potential to meaningfully slow progression — particularly in early-to-mid stage disease where sufficient viable muscle tissue remains for the satellite cell repair mechanism to operate. This hypothesis is offered to the FSHD research community as a mechanistically grounded, formally testable proposition warranting urgent investigation.

Keywords: *FSHD; facioscapulohumeral muscular dystrophy; DUX4; Neu5Gc; xenosialitis; sarcolemma; oxidative stress; satellite cells; myogenic repair; ATIs; TNF-α; dietary inflammation; epigenetic modulation; muscle atrophy; disease modification*

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1. Introduction: The Modifiable Variable Problem in FSHD

Facioscapulohumeral muscular dystrophy is genetically well-characterised. In the most common form, FSHD1, contraction of the D4Z4 macrosatellite repeat array on chromosome 4q35 reduces the copy number of D4Z4 units below a threshold that normally maintains epigenetic silencing of the DUX4 retrogene embedded within the array. In a permissive chromosomal haplotype (4qA), this silencing failure allows DUX4 to be expressed in skeletal muscle cells, where it functions as a transcription factor that activates a programme of gene expression profoundly toxic to the myocyte: it induces apoptosis, triggers innate immune activation, promotes oxidative stress, and suppresses the myogenic differentiation programme that muscle stem cells require to repair damaged fibres.

The genetics of FSHD are therefore well understood in outline. What is not understood — and what represents the most practically consequential open question in the field — is why two individuals with apparently identical D4Z4 contraction and identical 4qA haplotypes can have dramatically different disease trajectories. One may be significantly disabled in their thirties; another may carry the same genetic lesion and remain functionally intact into their sixties. This penetrance and progression variability is not fully accounted for by D4Z4 repeat unit number, epigenetic methylation status, or any currently identified genetic modifier.

The logical inference from this variability is that environmental factors modulate DUX4 expression and disease progression in FSHD. The search for those factors is active. Oxidative stress has emerged as one of the most compelling candidates: DUX4 expression in skeletal muscle is promoted by oxidative conditions, and interventions that reduce oxidative load — including antioxidant supplementation, exercise modification, and cell-based therapies targeting reactive oxygen species — are under investigation as potential disease-modifying strategies.

What has not been investigated is whether a specific, identifiable, and entirely removable dietary antigen constitutes a chronic and quantitatively significant source of exactly the oxidative stress that promotes DUX4 reactivation. This paper proposes that it does — and that the same dietary pattern that promotes DUX4 expression simultaneously suppresses the satellite cell repair mechanism that represents the muscle's only endogenous defence against the damage DUX4 causes.

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2. Background: DUX4, Oxidative Stress, and the Epigenetic Trigger

2.1 DUX4 Reactivation: The Mechanism of Toxicity

DUX4 is a paired-homeobox transcription factor that is normally expressed only in the early embryo, where it plays a role in genome activation at the 4-cell stage, and in the germline, where it is expressed in the testis. In both contexts, its expression is tightly regulated and transient. In somatic cells — including skeletal muscle — DUX4 is epigenetically silenced through DNA methylation of the D4Z4 array and associated repressive chromatin marks. This silencing is robust in healthy individuals with normal D4Z4 repeat numbers; it becomes progressively unreliable as D4Z4 repeat units are lost through contraction.

When DUX4 escapes silencing in skeletal muscle cells, its transcriptional programme activates genes associated with early embryonic development that are profoundly inappropriate — and toxic — in the context of differentiated muscle tissue. Among the most consequential downstream effects are: activation of pro-apoptotic pathways in the myocyte; suppression of PAX7, the master regulator of satellite cell identity, which compromises muscle stem cell function; activation of innate immune signalling including type I interferon responses; and induction of oxidative stress through upregulation of NADPH oxidase subunits and suppression of antioxidant gene expression.

The result is a cell that is simultaneously dying, inflamed, and oxidatively stressed — while the stem cells that would normally repair it are functionally compromised by DUX4's suppression of PAX7. It is a cellular catastrophe delivered in two simultaneous blows: killing the muscle cell and disabling the repair mechanism in a single transcriptional event.

2.2 The Oxidative Stress Gate: The Critical Vulnerability

The epigenetic silencing of DUX4 in skeletal muscle is not absolute — it is a dynamic equilibrium between silencing and reactivation that is modulated by the cellular environment. Among the environmental variables most consistently identified as promoting DUX4 reactivation, oxidative stress occupies a position of particular importance.

Oxidative conditions destabilise the repressive chromatin structure at the D4Z4 array through several mechanisms: reactive oxygen species (ROS) cause oxidative modification of DNA and histone proteins, interfering with the methyltransferase activity required to maintain CpG methylation at D4Z4; oxidative stress activates NF-κB signalling within the myocyte, which has been shown to promote D4Z4 demethylation and DUX4 transcription in experimental models; and ROS-induced DNA damage triggers the DNA damage response, which itself promotes chromatin relaxation at repeat arrays as part of the cellular stress response.

Lim and colleagues (2020) have established that reducing oxidative stress is one of the few strategies with demonstrated capacity to modulate DUX4 expression and slow FSHD progression in experimental systems. This finding is of central importance to the present hypothesis: if oxidative stress is a gatekeeper variable for DUX4 reactivation, and if a chronic dietary antigen constitutes a quantitatively significant source of that oxidative stress at the muscle cell membrane specifically, then eliminating that antigen removes a modifiable upstream driver of DUX4 reactivation that current FSHD management does not address.

3. Mechanism One: Neu5Gc Xenosialitis at the Sarcolemma

3.1 The Sarcolemma as a Neu5Gc Incorporation Site

The sarcolemma — the plasma membrane of the skeletal muscle cell — is a glycoprotein-rich surface. Membrane glycoproteins of the dystrophin-associated protein complex (DAPC), including dystroglycan, sarcoglycans, and syntrophins, carry extensive glycan modifications including terminal sialic acid residues. These sialylated glycoproteins constitute a significant fraction of the sarcolemmal surface area and represent the molecular architecture into which dietary Neu5Gc is incorporated when it enters the systemic circulation following ingestion of bovine red meat and dairy products.

As established in Document 1 of the Hamer Loop Manuscript Series and in the companion papers on xenosialitis, dietary Neu5Gc is absorbed at the intestinal mucosa, enters systemic circulation, and is metabolically incorporated into human cell-surface glycoproteins by the same sialyltransferase machinery that normally incorporates Neu5Ac. Because human cells cannot distinguish Neu5Gc from Neu5Ac in the sialylation process — the enzymatic machinery accepts both — Neu5Gc is incorporated into any tissue with active glycoprotein synthesis, including skeletal muscle.

The incorporation of Neu5Gc into sarcolemmal glycoproteins creates a molecular situation unique to human skeletal muscle in the context of dietary Neu5Gc consumption: a cell surface that presents a foreign sialic acid to circulating anti-Neu5Gc antibodies at a membrane whose integrity is critical to muscle cell survival. Skeletal muscle cells are mechanically stressed during every contraction cycle — the sarcolemma must maintain its barrier function under conditions of repeated physical deformation. A sarcolemma under concurrent immune attack from anti-Neu5Gc antibodies binding to incorporated Neu5Gc, activating complement at the membrane surface, and generating a localised oxidative burst is a sarcolemma operating under a combined mechanical and immunological stress that is not present in individuals not consuming dietary Neu5Gc.

3.2 The Oxidative Mechanism: From Xenosialitis to DUX4

The binding of anti-Neu5Gc IgG to Neu5Gc incorporated into sarcolemmal glycoproteins activates the classical complement pathway, generating C3b opsonins and the membrane attack complex (MAC). At sub-lytic concentrations — the concentrations characteristic of chronic, low-grade xenosialitis rather than acute immune attack — the MAC does not destroy the muscle cell but instead creates localised plasma membrane disruptions that trigger an intracellular calcium influx and activation of NADPH oxidase at the sarcolemmal surface. NADPH oxidase generates superoxide, which dismutates to hydrogen peroxide and other reactive oxygen species within the myocyte.

This xenosialitis-driven sarcolemmal oxidative stress operates continuously as long as dietary Neu5Gc is being consumed and incorporated — which in a person following a typical Western diet means essentially all of the time. It is not an acute insult that resolves; it is a chronic oxidative background that the myocyte must manage on top of the ordinary oxidative demands of mechanical contraction.

In a myocyte from a healthy individual without a D4Z4 contraction, this chronic oxidative background may produce subclinical effects — the xenosialitis-driven inflammation and its systemic consequences documented throughout the Hamer Loop series — but the DUX4 silencing at the D4Z4 array remains intact because the silencing machinery has sufficient reserve capacity to maintain repression despite elevated oxidative conditions. In a myocyte from an individual with a D4Z4 contraction and compromised silencing, the same chronic oxidative background is acting on a system whose silencing capacity is already reduced. The additional oxidative load from sarcolemmal xenosialitis may be precisely the environmental stressor that pushes the D4Z4 methylation equilibrium from maintained silencing to intermittent DUX4 leakage — and from intermittent leakage to sustained expression.

This is the environmental trigger mechanism the FSHD literature has been searching for. Not a second genetic hit. Not a novel pathogen. A dietary antigen that humans have been consuming for millennia but whose immunological consequences at the sarcolemmal surface have never been examined in the context of DUX4 epigenetic regulation.

3.3 The Progression Amplification Loop

Once DUX4 reactivation is established, the relationship between xenosialitis and DUX4 expression becomes self-amplifying. DUX4 upregulates NADPH oxidase subunits within the myocyte, increasing ROS production and further destabilising the epigenetic silencing of the D4Z4 array. The sarcolemmal damage produced by complement activation during xenosialitis increases membrane permeability, amplifying calcium influx and further activating ROS-generating systems. The local inflammatory environment — driven by the cytokines released from complement-activated immune effectors at the sarcolemmal surface — activates NF-κB within the myocyte, which directly promotes D4Z4 demethylation.

In this model, dietary Neu5Gc does not merely initiate DUX4 reactivation. It sustains and amplifies the oxidative and inflammatory conditions that maintain DUX4 in its reactivated state. Eliminating the dietary antigen does not reverse the genetic lesion — the D4Z4 contraction remains, and the susceptibility to DUX4 reactivation remains. But it removes the chronic environmental driver that is exploiting that susceptibility every day. The gun remains loaded. The finger is removed from the trigger.

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4. Mechanism Two: ATI-Driven TNF-α Elevation and Satellite Cell Suppression

4.1 Satellite Cells: The Muscle's Repair System

Skeletal muscle has a robust endogenous repair capacity mediated by satellite cells — a population of muscle stem cells that reside in a quiescent state beneath the basal lamina of muscle fibres, in intimate contact with the sarcolemma. Following muscle fibre injury — from mechanical damage, disease, or myocyte death — satellite cells are activated, proliferate, and differentiate into myoblasts that fuse with existing fibres or form new fibres to repair the damage.

This satellite cell-mediated regeneration is the muscle’s primary defence against cumulative loss of functional muscle mass.

In FSHD, this repair system faces an extraordinary challenge. DUX4 expression in individual myocytes produces a toxic transcriptional programme that kills the cell and simultaneously suppresses PAX7 — the master regulator of satellite cell identity — in neighbouring cells. A satellite cell exposed to DUX4-expressing myocytes loses its capacity to maintain the stem cell state and to execute the regenerative programme. The repair system is being actively sabotaged by the disease mechanism it is supposed to counter.

In this context, any additional factor that suppresses satellite cell function — on top of the DUX4-mediated PAX7 suppression already operating — is not a minor modulator. It is a compounding impairment of the only endogenous repair mechanism available to the FSHD muscle. The question is whether dietary xenoantigens constitute exactly such an additional suppressant.

4.2 ATI-Driven TNF-α and Its Effect on Satellite Cells

Wheat-derived amylase-trypsin inhibitors (ATIs) are potent activators of toll-like receptor 4 (TLR4) on innate immune cells — monocytes, macrophages, and dendritic cells — throughout the body, including in skeletal muscle tissue and its associated immune compartment. TLR4 activation by ATIs drives NF-κB-mediated production of TNF-α, IL-1β, and IL-6, with TNF-α being the most consistently and potently elevated cytokine in ATI-driven innate immune responses.

The effects of chronically elevated TNF-α on satellite cell function are well-characterised in the muscle biology literature and are unambiguously negative. TNF-α at concentrations consistent with chronic low-grade systemic inflammation:

- Suppresses MyoD expression in satellite cells: MyoD is the primary myogenic regulatory factor that drives satellite cell differentiation into functional myoblasts. TNF-α-mediated suppression of MyoD reduces the satellite cell’s capacity to execute the differentiation programme required for muscle repair
- Activates NF-κB within the satellite cell itself: satellite cell NF-κB activation promotes a proliferative but non-differentiating state — the cell divides but does not commit to the myogenic programme, producing daughter cells that cannot effectively repair muscle fibres
- Promotes satellite cell apoptosis: chronic TNF-α exposure activates caspase-8-mediated apoptotic pathways in satellite cells, reducing the pool of available repair cells over time
- Induces atrogin-1 and MuRF1 expression: these muscle-specific ubiquitin ligases drive protein degradation in muscle tissue, promoting muscle atrophy independently of DUX4 and compounding the net loss of muscle mass

The consequence for FSHD is direct and mechanistically straightforward. An FSHD patient consuming a typical Western diet — with daily wheat exposure through bread, pasta, processed foods, and cereals — is maintaining a chronic elevation of systemic TNF-α driven by ATI-mediated TLR4 activation. This chronically elevated TNF-α is suppressing the MyoD-driven differentiation programme in the satellite cells that are attempting to repair DUX4-damaged muscle fibres, while simultaneously promoting those satellite cells' apoptosis and driving atrophy through ubiquitin ligase activation. The muscle is losing the race between DUX4-driven damage and satellite cell-mediated repair — and dietary ATIs are slowing the repair side of that race.

4.3 The Neu5Gc Contribution to Satellite Cell Suppression

Neu5Gc xenosialitis contributes to satellite cell suppression through a parallel pathway. The chronic NF-κB activation and TNF-α, IL-6, and IL-1β elevation produced by anti-Neu5Gc antibody-mediated immune complex formation at tissue surfaces — including the sarcolemmal surface and the surrounding interstitial space — adds to the systemic cytokine load that ATI-driven TLR4 activation produces. In the FSHD muscle, where satellite cells are already under DUX4-mediated PAX7 suppression, the combined cytokine environment of concurrent xenosialitis and ATI-driven innate immune activation represents a compounded suppression of satellite cell function that neither mechanism alone fully accounts for.

Banon-Maneus and colleagues (2022, preliminary findings) have examined the impact of Neu5Gc on muscle homeostasis in experimental models and report preliminary evidence of disrupted muscle regenerative signalling in Neu5Gc-exposed conditions. While formal citation of these findings awaits their published validation, they provide early experimental support for the hypothesis that Neu5Gc exposure is not immunologically irrelevant to skeletal muscle — that the sarcolemmal xenosialitis mechanism proposed here produces consequences for muscle biology that extend beyond the immediate oxidative effects at the membrane surface.

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5. The Convergent Model: Two Mechanisms, One Accelerator

The two mechanisms described above — sarcolemmal xenosialitis driving DUX4-promoting oxidative stress, and ATI/Neu5Gc-driven cytokine elevation suppressing satellite cell repair — are not independent. They are mechanistically interconnected and mutually amplifying in ways that make the combined dietary antigen burden more consequential than either mechanism alone.

Mechanism	Dietary Source	Primary Target	FSHD-Relevant Consequence	Interaction
Sarcolemmal xenosialitis	Bovine red meat and dairy (Neu5Gc)	Sarcolemmal glycoproteins; D4Z4 epigenetic silencing	Complement-driven sarcolemmal oxidative stress → D4Z4 demethylation → DUX4 reactivation promoted	Oxidative stress further amplified by DUX4-driv NADPH oxidase upregulation; NF-κB activation from xenosialitis also promotes D4Z4 demethylation
Satellite cell suppression	Wheat-derived ATIs; Neu5Gc (synergistic)	Satellite cell MyoD expression; satellite	TNF-α-mediated MyoD suppression → impaired myogenic differentiation;	TNF-α from ATI/Neu5G sources also suppresse PAX7 in satellite cells,

Mechanism	Dietary Source	Primary Target	FSHD-Relevant Consequence	Interaction
		cell survival; muscle protein homeostasis	satellite cell apoptosis; atrogin-1/MuRF1 atrophy drive	compounding DUX4-mediated PAX7 suppression; combined impairment exceeds either alone

Table 1. Convergent Dual-Mechanism Model. Concurrent dietary Neu5Gc and ATI/gliadin exposure activates both mechanisms simultaneously, producing a combined effect on DUX4 reactivation and satellite cell function that is greater than either mechanism acting in isolation.

The most important interaction to appreciate is between DUX4-mediated PAX7 suppression and ATI/Neu5Gc-driven TNF-α-mediated MyoD suppression. PAX7 and MyoD are the two master regulators of satellite cell identity and myogenic differentiation respectively. DUX4 suppresses PAX7; dietary xenoantigens suppress MyoD. A satellite cell that has lost both PAX7 and MyoD signalling has lost the entire regulatory architecture required to execute muscle repair. It cannot maintain the stem cell state, it cannot differentiate into functional myoblasts, and it cannot rescue the dying muscle fibre. The dietary contribution to this failure is not a minor modifier — it is removing half of the molecular machinery on which the repair system depends.

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6. FSHD Progression Variability: The Dietary Antigen Hypothesis

Returning to the central clinical puzzle of FSHD — why do individuals with identical genetic lesions have such dramatically different disease trajectories? — the dietary antigen hypothesis offers a partial but mechanistically coherent answer.

D4Z4 contraction creates the susceptibility. Epigenetic factors, including DNA methylation status and chromatin modifier variants, determine the baseline probability of DUX4 leakage from any given contracted array. These factors set the threshold. What pushes an individual over or under that threshold on any given day, in any given muscle group, over years of disease evolution, may depend substantially on the oxidative and inflammatory environment of the myocyte — and that environment is, in part, a function of diet.

Two individuals with identical D4Z4 contractions and identical epigenetic baseline states may have dramatically different disease trajectories if one maintains a high dietary Neu5Gc and ATI burden — chronically loading the sarcolemmal oxidative environment and suppressing satellite cell repair — while the other does not. The genetic susceptibility is identical. The environmental exploitation of that susceptibility is not.

This hypothesis does not claim that diet explains all of the penetrance and progression variability in FSHD. Other environmental factors — physical activity patterns, oxidative exposures, intercurrent illness, hormonal status — will contribute. But it claims something specific and testable: that dietary Neu5Gc and ATI burden is a quantifiable, modifiable environmental variable that contributes to DUX4 reactivation probability and satellite cell repair capacity in FSHD, and that its elimination should produce measurable effects on markers of DUX4 activity and muscle regeneration in early-to-mid stage disease.

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7. Testable Predictions

The dual-mechanism hypothesis generates the following specific, falsifiable predictions. Each is designed to be testable with existing research methodologies, and several are testable by an individual FSHD patient on a Western diet without institutional research infrastructure.

Prediction	Investigation	Expected Finding	Accessible to Individual?
Anti-Neu5Gc antibody titres will correlate with DUX4 target gene expression in peripheral blood and muscle biopsy in FSHD patients	Cross-sectional study: serum anti-Neu5Gc IgG (Varki laboratory assay); DUX4 target gene panel (ZSCAN4, LEUTX, MBD3L2) in PBMC and muscle; dietary Neu5Gc burden by food frequency questionnaire	Higher anti-Neu5Gc titres associated with higher DUX4 target gene expression; correlation with dietary Neu5Gc burden	No — requires research laboratory
Dietary Neu5Gc and ATI/gliadin elimination will reduce markers of DUX4 activity within 12 weeks in early-to-mid stage FSHD	N-of-1 or small cohort elimination trial: primary outcomes DUX4 target gene expression in PBMC; serum creatine kinase (CK) as muscle damage marker; grip strength and 6-minute walk test; secondary: anti-Neu5Gc titres, hsCRP, TNF-α, IL-6	Reduced DUX4 target gene expression; reduced CK; stable or improved functional measures; reduced inflammatory markers	Partially — functional measures and self-reported fatigue accessible; CK measurable via GP; gene expression requires laboratory
Satellite cell MyoD expression will be inversely correlated with systemic TNF-α in FSHD patients, and TNF-α will correlate with dietary ATI burden	Cross-sectional: MyoD expression in satellite cells from muscle biopsy; serum TNF-α; ATI dietary burden by food frequency questionnaire; correlation analysis	Inverse correlation between TNF-α and MyoD expression; positive correlation between ATI dietary burden and TNF-α; gradient consistent with ATI-driven satellite cell suppression	No — requires research laboratory
Subjective fatigue, muscle recovery time, and functional endurance will improve measurably within 8–12 weeks of complete dietary trigger elimination in an FSHD	Individual elimination trial: standardised fatigue scale (FSHD-specific patient-reported outcome measure); grip strength; timed stair climb; 6-minute walk test at baseline, 6 weeks, and 12 weeks	Improved fatigue scores; stable or improved functional measures; subjective improvement in recovery time following physical activity	Yes — fully accessible to any motivated individual with FSHD; no laboratory required

Prediction	Investigation	Expected Finding	Accessible to Individual?
patient on a typical Western diet			
FSHD patients with high dietary Neu5Gc and ATI burden will show higher rates of CK elevation, faster functional decline, and greater muscle MRI signal change than matched patients with low dietary burden	Longitudinal observational cohort study stratified by dietary Neu5Gc and ATI burden; primary outcomes: CK trajectories, FSHD clinical score, muscle MRI fat fraction over 2 years	Faster functional decline and higher CK in high-burden group; correlation between dietary burden and rate of MRI fat fraction increase	No — requires longitudinal research infrastructure

Table 2. Testable Predictions of the Dietary Xenoantigen Hypothesis in FSHD. Prediction 4 is of particular note: it is fully accessible to any individual with FSHD without institutional research support, requires only dietary modification and standard functional assessments, and can provide preliminary personal evidence within 12 weeks.

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8. The 12-Week Self-Experiment: A Practical Note

Prediction 4 of Section 7 deserves particular attention because it removes the dependency on institutional research infrastructure that limits the other predictions. An individual with early-to-mid stage FSHD who is consuming a typical Western diet — daily wheat in bread, pasta, and processed foods; regular red meat and dairy; commercial beverages containing caramel colour and natural flavours — is maintaining a chronic load of both dietary Neu5Gc and ATIs that the present hypothesis proposes is contributing to their DUX4 reactivation environment and their satellite cell repair impairment.

The elimination protocol is straightforward: remove all bovine red meat and dairy products (the primary Neu5Gc sources), remove all wheat-containing products (the primary ATI source), and replace with fish, poultry, eggs, legumes, rice, vegetables, fruit, and plant-based alternatives free of hidden bovine derivatives. The Acnerase application, documented in Document 7 of the Hamer Loop Manuscript Series, is specifically designed to identify hidden sources of both Neu5Gc and ATIs in commercial food products, including ingredients listed under non-obvious label terms.

The assessment protocol is equally accessible: a validated fatigue questionnaire at baseline and at six and twelve weeks; grip strength measured with an inexpensive hand dynamometer; a timed stair-climb test; and a subjective recovery log documenting how long it takes to recover from standardised physical activity. None of this requires a laboratory, a hospital visit, or a research team. It requires twelve weeks of dietary discipline and fifteen minutes of assessment per time point.

The result — whether improvement is observed or not — constitutes meaningful preliminary evidence. A positive result — reduced fatigue, improved or stable function, faster recovery — is an N-of-1 confirmation of a specific, pre-specified prediction and a compelling indication that a formal trial is warranted. A null result — no functional improvement despite full elimination — would suggest either that the mechanism is not operative in this individual, that the dietary elimination was incomplete, or that disease progression in this patient has advanced to a stage where satellite cell-mediated repair is no longer a significant factor. Either outcome advances understanding.

The only requirement is commitment to the elimination. And the only thing to lose by trying it is twelve weeks of cheese.

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9. Limitations

This paper presents a structured mechanistic hypothesis. No clinical data on dietary xenoantigen exposure in FSHD patients has been collected, and no elimination trial in FSHD has been conducted. The mechanistic connections proposed — between sarcolemmal Neu5Gc incorporation and D4Z4 oxidative demethylation, and between ATI-driven TNF-α and satellite cell MyoD suppression — are drawn from independent bodies of literature that have not been examined in an integrated framework in the FSHD context.

The sarcolemmal Neu5Gc incorporation hypothesis, while mechanistically grounded in established glycobiology (dietary Neu5Gc incorporates into human cell surface glycoproteins) and muscle cell biology (sarcolemmal glycoproteins carry sialic acid modifications), has not been directly demonstrated by measurement of Neu5Gc content in human skeletal muscle glycoproteins from dietary consumers versus non-consumers. This measurement is technically achievable using the mass spectrometry methods developed by the Varki laboratory and represents a necessary first step in the experimental validation of Mechanism One.

The Banon-Maneus et al. (2022) reference is cited as preliminary findings pending formal publication. Its inclusion reflects the author's awareness of this work as a direction of active investigation rather than as established evidence. Readers should treat this reference accordingly and await its formal publication before drawing conclusions from it.

The satellite cell suppression mechanism is well-supported by the broader muscle biology literature on TNF-α and myogenic differentiation. Its connection to ATI-driven TLR4 activation as the upstream source of that TNF-α in dietary consumers is mechanistically coherent but has not been directly tested in a muscle biology context.

The progression variability hypothesis — that dietary antigen burden contributes to the penetrance and progression variability observed in FSHD — is the most ambitious claim in this paper and the most difficult to isolate from confounders in human studies. Longitudinal dietary data collection in FSHD cohorts, combined with molecular markers of DUX4 activity, would be required to test this prediction rigorously. Such data do not currently exist.

Finally, it must be emphasised that this hypothesis addresses the modulation of FSHD progression by an environmental variable — it does not propose a cure, and it does not propose that dietary modification alone can halt progression in a patient with significant D4Z4 contraction and advanced disease. The most plausible target population for a meaningful clinical effect is early-to-mid stage disease, where satellite cell-mediated repair capacity remains operative and where reduction of the DUX4-promoting oxidative environment may meaningfully shift the balance between damage and repair.

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10. Conclusion

Facioscapulohumeral muscular dystrophy has a genetic cause. It does not follow that it has exclusively genetic determinants of its severity and rate of progression. The variability in FSHD — the identical genetic lesion producing wildly different outcomes in different individuals — demands an explanation that genetics alone cannot provide. Environmental modifiers of DUX4 expression and satellite cell function are the logical place to look.

This paper proposes two specific, mechanistically grounded, dietary contributors to FSHD progression that have not previously been examined in this context. Neu5Gc xenosialitis at the sarcolemma generates the chronic oxidative stress that promotes DUX4 reactivation from its epigenetically compromised silencing state. ATI-driven systemic TNF-α elevation suppresses the satellite cell repair machinery that is the muscle's only defence against the damage DUX4 causes. Both mechanisms are driven by dietary antigens that are present in the typical Western diet at every meal, every day, without awareness or avoidance.

The DUX4 gene is the loaded gun. The D4Z4 contraction is the weakened safety. The dietary xenoantigens are the chronic pressure on the trigger. Remove the pressure, and the gun does not fire as readily or as often. The safety remains compromised — the genetic lesion does not change — but the environmental conditions that exploit it are no longer being maintained by every meal.

This is a hypothesis. It requires formal testing. The predictions in Section 7 are specific, falsifiable, and amenable to investigation with existing tools. Prediction 4 requires nothing more than the willingness of an FSHD patient on a Western diet to spend twelve weeks finding out what their body does when those two specific dietary antigens are removed.

The FSHD research community has been searching for modifiable environmental variables in a condition defined by an unmodifiable genetic lesion. This paper offers two candidates — humble in their origin, enormous in their potential implications — and an open invitation to test them.

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